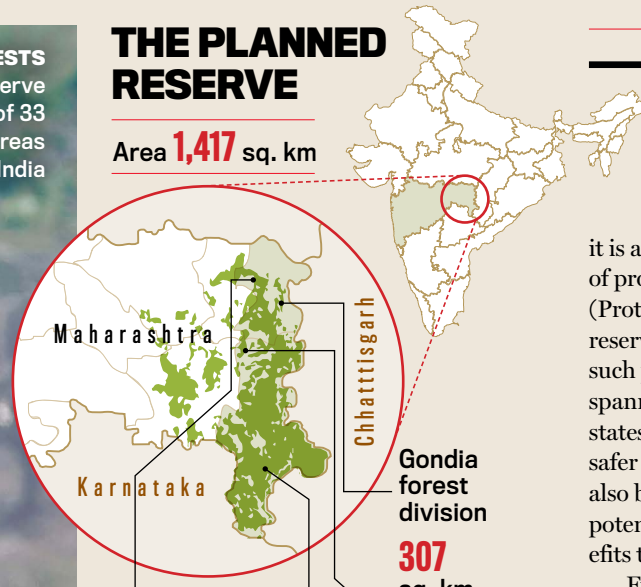


TUSKED GUESTS
The new elephant reserve will join a network of 33 such protected areas across India

THE PLANNED RESERVE

Area **1,417** sq. km



NNTR core and buffer	Gadchiroli forest division	Gondia forest division	Wadsa forest division
321 sq. km	240 sq. km	307 sq. km	549 sq. km

Note: This covers 37 villages in Gondia, 69 in Wadsa and 31 in Gadchiroli

More tragically, there have been human casualties. Last September, Sudhakar Atram, a forest department driver, lost his life when a tusker charged and trampled him during a routine patrol in Armori forest range. According to Uday Patel, honorary wildlife warden, Gadchiroli, at least four people have been killed in elephant attacks this year alone.

To mitigate these human-wildlife conflicts, the forest department has deployed high-tech solutions. Thermal drones and trackers monitor the elephants' movements round the clock, allowing officials to anticipate potential flashpoints and intervene proactively. But technology alone cannot solve the underlying issues. This is where the proposed elephant reserve comes into play.

THE HERD OF 27 WILD ELEPHANTS, WHO WANDERED IN HERE FROM CHHATTISGARH, HAVE STIRRED BOTH OPTIMISM AND WORRY AMONG ECOLOGISTS

Maheep Gupta, principal chief conservator of forests and chief wildlife warden, Maharashtra, confirmed that a proposal to notify an elephant reserve was sent to the state government earlier this year. "The government is considering it," he says. If and when that clearance comes, it will be sent to the Union government for notification. "The wildlife management plan will be made in such a way that it helps develop an elephant habitat," he says. For this, the department is hopeful of receiving funds under Project Elephant—a centrally sponsored scheme launched in 1992-93 to restore elephant habitats and mitigate human-wildlife conflict.

The country has around 30,000 wild elephants, as per a 2017 population estimation. Apart from being India's national animal, it is also a Schedule-1 species, which means that it is accorded the highest degree of protection under the Wildlife (Protection) Act, 1972. The new reserve would join a network of 33 such protected areas across India, spanning over 80,000 sq. km in 10 states. It would not only provide a safer haven for the elephants but also boost eco-tourism in the region, potentially bringing economic benefits to local communities.

Further, the reserve will help ensure that focused conservation strategies are developed, says an Indian Forest Service (IFS) officer from the region—for instance, incorporating elephant-specific mitigation measures in infrastructure projects. Instead of the standard clearance of two to three metres for wildlife underpasses in road projects, he explains, a clearance of seven to eight metres will be recommended to accommodate elephants.

However, some experts caution that creating a reserve will not suffice as a panacea. A state forest official points out that while the reserve will help develop the habitat, it won't change the agricultural patterns or human settlements in the area—the root causes of many conflicts. "Elephants are migratory, not territorial," the source explains. "This herd may move on again in search of food." So, the challenge lies in managing their presence within the established human landscape.

Despite these challenges, the proposal for the elephant reserve has garnered support from wildlife experts and officials alike. Patel, for instance, believes the reserve will aid in "mitigation, awareness and reducing human-elephant conflict". He emphasises the importance of maintaining deciduous trees and bamboo plantations as food sources for the elephants. As Maharashtra awaits its jumbo-sized decision, the tusked guests seem content with their new vacation home. ■